At the time, other than Longowal, most senior Akali leaders were in preventive detention in various jails because of ongoing Dharam Yudh Morcha. Badal was in Ludhiana jail, and the others, including Tohra, were in Ferozepur jail. Travelling in his personal car mostly in the dead of the night, Swaran Singh met all the senior Akali leaders in jail as well as Longowal, who was directing the morcha from the Golden Temple, more than once. While trying to ascertain their views on the minimum acceptable demands, which could help them take a decision to withdraw the morcha, Swaran Singh advised them to agree to a reasonably acceptable solution.

As a first step towards facilitating Swaran Singh's talks with the Akali leaders as a group, all the leaders were released from jail on 15 October 1982. Following this, Swaran Singh had several meetings with them and discussed their demands, some of which were quite mundane. 'The Anandpur Sahib Resolution was the principal snag. Swaran Singh told the Akalis he could only discuss with them matters concerning Centre-state relations and nothing beyond.' [12]

The Akalis held several meetings among themselves and watered down their demands for devolution of power to the states, as compared to what was mentioned in the Anandpur Sahib Resolution. Swaran Singh was finally able to convince the Akalis that the matter should be left to Indira Gandhi, who could consider appointing a committee to examine the Anandpur Sahib Resolution.

As no solution would have been possible without taking Bhindranwale on board, Swaran Singh went to meet him at Guru Nanak Niwas. When Swaran Singh walked into Bhindranwale's room, he found journalist Kuldip Nayar there. Nayar has described that meeting in his autobiography. [13]

> Once I caught up with Bhindranwale in his very untidy room and I asked him why he was surrounded by so many armed men toting rifles and Sten guns. His reply, in rustic Punjabi, was to ask why the police carried guns. I told him police represented authority; to which he retorted, 'Let them ever challenge me, and I shall show them who has the authority.'